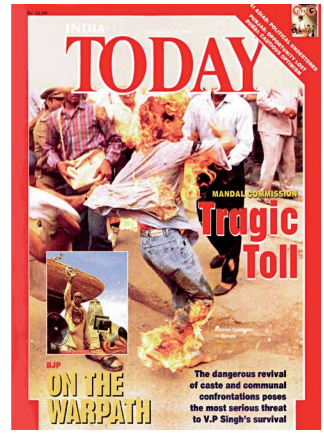
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Casteism is one of India's worst curses. Although officially condemned, it permeates every aspect of Indian life. Instead of endeavouring to eliminate this blight, politicians promote it in order to acquire or retain power. The most recent example of this is the demand for a nation-wide caste census, which marks a second Mandal moment in Indian politics. Even though Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar chose the high-minded symbolism of October 2 to release the results of the state's caste-based survey, he has stirred the political cauldron keeping in mind the general election due in 2024. Till now, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has led the way with such force and imagination that it compels opponents into a weak reactive mode that already puts them on a losing trajectory. However, Nitish's political googly has attempted to put the BJP on the defensive. That's why the Congress and others have swung around to backing a nation-wide caste census with gusto. In seeking to take ownership of the pro-backwards plank, the INDIA alliance spies a potentially effective counter to the BJP's Hindutva.



Our October 15, 1990 cover on the Mandal agitation

A gladiatorial Modi will not necessarily be forced on the back foot by this. Take his fierce counterattack at his October 3 rally in Jagdalpur, Chhattisgarh, where he said, "The poor are the largest population." This was a counter to Rahul Gandhi's variation on the old Kanshi Ram slogan—*Jitni aabaadi, utna haq* (rights in proportion to the population). But it was a rare piece of reactive battlefield offensive. Even while going on the front foot, the caste census question does leave the BJP guessing about which way the ball will turn. It touches on an inner dilemma the party has not yet entirely resolved: it neither wants to play the ball, nor leave it. If the 1990s were about a stark binary tussle between Mandal and Mandir, the BJP has evolved in the intervening three decades. Its present model of Hindutva is acutely sensitive to caste. It has consciously made an effort to change its image of being a party dominated by the privileged castes to one that is more inclusive. The rise of Modi has further buttressed that effort. However, despite some votaries within it, the party has shied away from a caste census. The Bihar survey forces it to take a stand.

What Nitish Kumar released is the first-ever count of the Other Backward Classes (OBCs) that has been made official anywhere in India after the 1931 census. Its findings are revealing: OBCs and Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs) make up 63 per cent of the state's 130.7 million population. About 11 percentage points more than the national average of 52 per cent estimated in 1931, which was accepted even by the Mandal Commission. Along with the Scheduled Castes and Tribes, the non-privileged castes (including Muslim backwards) make up as much as 84 per cent of Bihar's population. In a robust democracy, just that knowledge is empowering because it is likely to lead to demands for a bigger share of the reservations pie. This could possibly be a factor even in the four big state elections around the corner. The idea of a caste census is such a potent weapon that even constituents of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance, like Union minister Anupriya Patel's Apna Dal (Sonelal), the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) and the Nishad Party unequivocally back it. Indeed, even some among the BJP are unwilling to relinquish ownership of it, as statements by former Bihar deputy CM Sushil Kumar Modi indicate.

The INDIA bloc too can bump up against the unpleasant paradoxes of caste-based politics. For instance, in Bihar, Nitish's JD(U) found its own identity around a segmentation of the state's OBCs, partly as a reaction to the Yadav dominance of backward politics via Lalu-Tejashwi's RJD. Beyond the politics, a serious skew can become visible even in the access to reserved jobs. Granular data on OBC sub-groups reveals the capture of quotas by dominant communities everywhere. Indeed, this has been the Modi government's prime argument too. In 2017, it set up the G. Rohini commission to examine the relative share in reservations of the 2,600-plus caste groups in the central OBC list. This July, after 14 extensions, the commission submitted its report. The final objective is to sub-categorise the OBC field to allow a more equitable distribution of benefits. The problem is, even this requires accurate caste population data, and leads back to the question of a census.

The BJP's reluctance on a caste census flows partly from its awareness of the practical complexities. But in large part, it's an ideological aversion. The RSS-BJP likes to view the Hindus as a unitary bloc, with religious affiliation overriding any other source of differentiation. Caste flies smack in the face of that. That's why the party prefers poverty, shorn of any social factors that cause it, as the primary category that should determine welfare. Undoubtedly, the BJP is in a dilemma about whether to now advocate a caste census going against their core beliefs. They could not have forgotten that in 2015, weeks before the Bihar election, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat had called for a "social review" of reservations. That, many believe, cost them that election. How this will play out, and whether the BJP refines its stand as the game proceeds, will be fascinating to watch. With Executive Editor Kaushik Deka, Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan and Senior Editor Amitabh Srivastava in Patna, we bring you a running commentary on what promises to be a big chapter in Indian politics.

A nation progresses only if all its people progress. The hubris of India's claims to be one of the world's major economies is shown up by our per capita income levels. And numerous surveys have shown the large overlap between caste and poverty—right up to the latest analyses of multidimensional poverty. There's by now at least a tenuous consensus around affirmative action even among those who formerly held out. One can insist, however, on its fairness of distribution and also propose judiciously time-barred reservations for groups that may be currently deprived but do not face social exclusion in perpetuity. Ultimately, for India to be a modern progressive nation, it must get away from giving state benefits on the basis of caste and work to identify the needy on other more relevant criteria.

(Aroon Purie)